

Unit 6 teacher notes

What this unit is for

This is the last unit of the course and the one that determines whether the previous five leave anything behind. Every earlier unit ends in a promise that only continuing development keeps: a profession rests on developing knowledge, competence is an ethical obligation, effectiveness components are not fixed, standards are for self-evaluation, and conditions are hard so what is within your control matters.

The deliverable is Topic 6.4's one-page plan. If the block runs short, protect that session above everything else, including the assessment. A cohort that leaves with a real plan has got more from this course than one that leaves with a good examination mark and no page.

Sequencing across the three-week block

Four topics over three weeks: 6.1 in Week 14, 6.2 and the first half of 6.3 in Week 15, the rest of 6.3 and 6.4 in Week 16.

Topic 6.3 is the longest in the unit and 6.4 must not be squeezed by it. If you are behind, cut the conference and online-platform sections of 6.3 to a brief treatment, and keep professional learning communities and lesson study, which are the two routes trainees can actually use.

Teach 6.1 before anything else and teach the six principles properly. Every later topic is scored against them, and a cohort that has not internalised them will read 6.3 as a list of options rather than as a comparison.

The misconceptions that recur

"Professional development means attending a workshop." The commonest belief in the field and the one the whole unit argues against. Mr Naeem's folder is the intervention; let the class reach the diagnosis rather than stating it.

"Development is what a system provides, so if none is provided none happens." Common and understandable in cohorts who have seen poor provision. The response is Topic 6.3's professional learning communities and reflective tools, which cost almost nothing, and Unit 5's control distinction.

"Experienced teachers have finished developing." Trainees hold this and so, quietly, do many serving teachers. The inverse arrangement of capacity and pressure in Topic 6.2 is the repair.

"A development plan is a document you write for an appraiser." If this survives, Topic 6.4 produces a page written to look good and the unit fails. Address it directly, and connect it to Unit 4's argument about mixing development with judgement, which the cohort has already accepted in another context.

"Reflective practice means keeping a diary." Correct with the three-sentence structure from Unit 3 rather than by argument: show them what a reflective entry looks like beside a diary entry.

Protecting the plan-building session

Topic 6.4's activity is the most important thirty-five minutes in the unit, and it fails in three predictable ways.

Trainees write six goals. They will, despite the one-goal rule, because narrowing feels like admitting defeat. Enforce it during the session rather than in marking. Ask each person to read their goal aloud; a six-goal plan cannot be read aloud as one sentence and the exercise exposes itself.

Gaps are stated as virtues. "I want to be more patient" is not a gap. Require that every gap names something an observer could see, and be prepared to send several people back to this block.

The time question is skipped. "Where does the hour come from" is the block trainees leave blank and the one that decides whether anything happens. Do not accept a plan without it.

Have trainees keep the page. Ask them to photograph it. A plan collected by you and filed becomes exactly the appraiser's document the topic warns against.

Practical work

Development audit (Week 14). The Topic 6.1 task asks three teachers what development they have attended and what they do differently. Brief the framing carefully: this is not an audit of whether those teachers are good, and if it is heard that way the answers will be defensive and useless.

Stage interviews (Week 15). The Topic 6.2 task asks a new and an experienced teacher what would actually help them. The answers are usually more modest and more specific than the topic predicts, and where they differ from the text, say plainly in the debrief that the teachers are the better evidence.

Observation question (Week 16). The Topic 6.3 task asks whether teachers in the school ever watch each other teach, and why not. The third reason, about how an observation would be received, is the one worth drawing out.

The plan (Week 16). Topic 6.4, described above.

Marking the unit assessment, and closing the course

ERQ 5 is the integrative item and the closing task of the whole course. It requires a real plan, a defence of each block, substantive use of at least three earlier units, and an honest naming of the plan's own weakest point. It is the best single indicator of whether the course was understood, because it cannot be answered from Unit 6 alone.

Two marking notes. The rubric rewards a candidate who names their plan's vulnerability; a plan presented as having no weak point should not reach the top band, because the self-diagnosis is the skill being assessed. And a gap that an observer could not confirm or disconfirm caps the first criterion however well the rest is written.

If you have time in the final session, do one thing: ask how many trainees expect to reopen their page in March. Take the honest count rather than the polite one, and say plainly that the count is what the course was for.

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